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It's Debatable

Debate Topic: _____

Your teacher will tell you whether you are going to argue for or against the topic. Prepare your argument in a small group and then present your views to your opponent. Once you have heard the other group's opinions, you must give a response.

When both groups have delivered their response to the other group's argument, your teacher or classmates will decide which group is the winner.

Use the following expressions when you are giving your opinions and disagreeing with the other group's ideas.

Giving your Opinion

In my opinion ...

I (don't) think that ...

I honestly feel that ...

The way I see it, ...

There's no doubt that ...

You can't deny that ...

I strongly believe that ...

As far as I'm concerned, ...

I'm convinced that ...

Disagreeing

I totally disagree that ...

It may be true that ..., but ...

I beg to differ.

I'm afraid I don't agree that ...

I see your point on ..., but...

I don't think so.

Notes:

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In this lively teaching activity, students engage in a debate to help them practice expressions for giving opinions and disagreeing.

Before class, make one copy of the worksheet for each student.

Procedure

Divide the class into an even number of groups with three or four students in each group.

Give each student a copy of the handout.

Write some for and against topics on the board. Write one topic for every 2 groups in the class, e.g. if you have ten groups, write five topics on the board.

Example Topics:

Animals should not be kept in zoos.
Actors and professional athletes are paid too much.
Boys and girls should study in separate classes.
People are too dependent on computers.
Wealthy nations should share their wealth among poorer nations.

Ask the groups to choose which topic they would like to debate. Two groups must choose the same topic. Then, tell each group, whether they are going to argue for or against the topic.

Go over the instructions with the class and draw the students' attention to the useful expressions for giving opinions and disagreeing.

The students then write their debate topic at the top of their worksheet and in their groups they prepare their arguments. Explain that each member of the group must contribute to the debate.

Encourage students to make notes on their worksheet to remind them what to say.

When everyone is ready, two groups come to the front of the class and debate their topic.

After each group has presented their arguments, the two groups respond to each other using the language to disagree and by giving counter-arguments.

When the debate is over, choose a winner and explain why they have won or have a class vote.

Then, the next two groups come to the front of the class and debate and so on.